

which messages bleep out in Hindi and English. As the coach shines on the steel rails, the interiors are transformed into a growing forest of frozen-framed limbs.

The train talks, almost without a pause, in the crisp voice of emcee Rini Khanna. She warns you not to touch untended objects because they could be bombs, informs you of the next station, tells you, in that very London slogan, to please mind the gap—between the train and the platform. Not everybody listens though. The mobile phone and the FM radio are standard accessories inside. They are a welcome distraction which help kill time on the hour-long commute, past a suburban sprawl of ugly three-and-four-storeyed buildings and 28 identical elevated stations. "You made me miss my station," wails the attractive college stu-

dent in bouncy black hair. "Now, I will have to get off at nine," she says into her Nokia. Nine, of course, is the sector where the train terminates.

Over 500 engineers and thousands of workers laboured for over a decade on the first phase of the Metro spinning a steel web of 65 km with 59 stations, at a budget of over Rs 10,000 crore. It has knocked dozens of cramped Delhi Transport Corporation buses off the route, halved travelling time and sexed-up droll stops like Karol Bagh. Which explains why trader Adhir Arora, who lives in Dwarka heaves a sigh of hindsight, "We should have had the Metro 40 or 50 years ago." With me-too clones planned in other cities like Bangalore, Hyderabad and even Mumbai, the rest of India will soon be wishing alike.

RAVI S SAHANI

THE AWE-STRUCK
FACES, RESERVED
FOR GAWKERS
FROM OUT OF
TOWN, ARE GIVING
WAY TO VACANT,
BUSINESS-AS-USUAL
FACES YOU WOULD
SEE ON ANY METRO
IN THE WORLD,
AS ARE THE SLEEK
WHITE INSIDES OF
THE COACHES WITH
DIGITAL CRAWLERS
ON WHICH
MESSAGES
SCROLL BY

